

It nearly didn't happen

Suzanne Thompson on getting Turraburra back.

Suzanne was driving out to finish a fence when her phone rang. It was the owner of the land her family had waited years to bring home. He was pulling out, selling because of drought — and just like that, the door was closing.

"He said, nah, I'm changing that. Now no one's going to get access. I'm shutting the gate."

She got out of the car. Called out to the old people. And in that moment, everything shifted.

"I said, no, we've got to buy this place. We can't allow this to happen. What about the grannies?"

She didn't know where to start. She turned to Graham first, then her sister [Cheryl?], and a family connection who could make the first quiet call to the agent [Ed Wood?] — without anyone knowing who was really behind it.

"We didn't want them to know it was for us. So we had to come in incognito."

Buying it was only the first hurdle. To actually hold the land, the family had to prove they could look after it — a workshop, a capability statement, everything her mother and sister had built laid out for people to see.

"By the end of that workshop, when we brought them out here, they were all out here to see it. And then I said to them, we can do this."

When the offer came, she asked for something more than money.

"This is going to be a hard journey. But bring my mum on the journey with us. Because we are so fragile."

On the 30th of April 2019, the last owner drove off the property.

"And then it was just us. There was Mum. There was Robin Adams. There was Graham. There was me."

There was no furniture in the house. They slept on the floor that first night.

"Mark got up and said shh. I said, what? He said, can you hear it? He said, this is ours. And we all got up, yay, and we were dancing around, because we couldn't believe what we'd done."

Her father runs underneath all of it — a man who spent his life fencing and protecting this Country, and never got to see this day. He died in 2003.

"My father helped me realise a dream. That was my father's dream."

Seven years later, the family signed the deed that made it official.

Image:

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/13hmMzMDbmNPnhjXMHRuHfc4hF2VsmYYO/view?usp=sharing>

Caption: Signing the deed of grant, 12:15pm, Friday 26 June 2026.

"We will be truly self-determined. But I guarantee, our work starts again from here."

With thanks to Uncle Winston Forrester, Robin Adams, [Steve?], [Trish?], and everyone else who helped get them here.